

Narrative Packages — Compare & Pick

Dark Matter: Genesis | Choose one package (or cherry-pick systems)
Designed content target: ≥150 hours each (**exploration excluded**)
Rebuild pass: Aug 2026 — mixed-purpose puzzles, AC progress curve, weapon rewards, progress-triggered mainline, ecology + systems roadmap tags
Canon lock (Aug 2026): Player **Kade** · AI spine **Kairos** (name learned end of prologue) — global across all packages

Quick Diff

Axis	V1 Ash & Signal	V2 Colony Horizon	V3 Fracture Compact	V4 Crimson Contract
Tone	Mystery / horror / lo-as-antagonist	Hope / colony-builder / legacy	Faction intrigue / politics	Off-beat freelancer / contract spectacle
AI spine name	Kairos (<i>learned end of prologue</i>)	Kairos (<i>learned end of prologue</i>)	Kairos (<i>learned end of prologue</i>)	Kairos (<i>learned end of prologue</i>)
AI truth	Precursor defense AI ; lo erased crew	Lost expedition archive ; cores = people	Corporate black-box ; cores = sync weapons / leverage	Contract Ledger AI ; cores = escrow keys / kill receipts / expedition gaps
Endings	Seal / Awaken / Symbiosis	Build / Evacuate / Seed	Expose / Weaponize / Broker	Walk Away / Crown the Company / Burn the Ledger
Mainline delivery	Progress triggers — not quest givers	Same; BCP / storm / colony flags	Same; Claim Barriers + Compact votes on sides	Same; Contract Locks + board jobs on sides
Friction emphasis	Silence, Resonance Shelves, Still Hunter, Ash Barrier	Weather windows, Building gates, Colony Barrier	Claim Barriers, Smuggler Seals, Compact Summit	Contract Locks, Escrow Seals, Siege Timers, Rival Crew ambushes, Client Override
Player fantasy	Survive a hostile moon that might be alive	Prove a colony deserves a future	Own the table; write the Compact	Freelance terraform surveyor — assess lo viability, find missing expeditions, survive contract-board spectacle
Starter setup	5000 AC · 1 skilled companion pick	5000 AC · 1 skilled companion pick	5000 AC · 1 skilled companion pick	5000 AC = 5% Mars final pay · 2 old-friend specialists (Reid Kael + Dr. Suri Vale, max trust day one)
Designed hours	165h	170h	174h	172h
Exploration	~25–40h bonus (untracked)	Same	Same	Same

Shared locks (all four)

lo 2160 · **Player Kade** · AC-only · 22+trio · repair **Kairos** → 6 Memory Cores → trust · biome order **B6→B1→B2→B3→B5→B4→B7** · ~40 sides · ~40 puzzles · 5 base + 2 external factions · Barrier Field pattern · Echo fail = permanent · base injury-not-death
Kairos naming: Pre-prologue UI uses liaison shell / probe / ledger machine labels. Player learns the name **Kairos** at **prologue end** in every package.

V4 player canon (package-specific)

Element	V4 rule
Player	Kade — freelance space explorer; ex- terraform director who started from the bottom; weapons-fluent, high IQ, discovery-driven
Mars backstory	Former employer stranded player on Mars → chose freelance → lo charter
5000 AC	5% of final Mars director pay — charter + partial retainer, not generic starter grant
Mission	Assess lo terraform viability + discover why past expeditions disappeared
Starter crew	Reid "Iron" Kael (Combat Tactician) + Dr. Suri Vale (Science Specialist) — old friends, complete trust from day one ; no wary starter loyalty arc
Drama source	lo, Kairos, clients, Echo stakes, mission ethics — not distrust of the player by Reid/Suri

Shared rebuild rules (this pass)

Rule	Implementation
Mixed-purpose puzzles	Each package labels ~40 puzzles: Access Gate (minority ~8), Loot/Cache/Weapon (~8), Environmental Survival (~7), Combat/Encounter (~6), Story/Reveal (~6), Optional Mastery (~5)
AC progress curve	T1 early hundreds → T4 late B4/B7/faction finales thousands
Weapons / upgrades	Named melee/ranged/hotbar gear + upgrade kits across mainline/sides/factions/puzzles
Ecology integration	Real B1–B7 / UG organisms from ecology roster + RT_LifeSheet_* art refs
Systems roadmap	[SHIPPED] / [PARTIAL] / [PLANNED] inventory doubles as content roadmap

AC Curve (shared design)

Tier	Acts / biomes	Mainline beats	Side quests	Mastery puzzles
T1	Act I · B6–B1	200–450 AC	250–500 AC	600–900 AC
T2	Act II · B2–B3	450–900 AC	500–950 AC	900–1500 AC
T3	Act III · B5–B4	900–1800 AC	1000–2000 AC	1500–2200 AC
T4	Act IV · B7 / finales	1800–3500 AC	2000–4500 AC	2200–3000 AC

Access-gate puzzles may pay low AC but unlock routes; loot/mastery puzzles carry the higher AC / weapon payoffs.

Faction Name Map (same slots, different brands)

Slot	V1	V2	V3	V4
Security	Ashwatch Cordons	Horizon Guard	Fracture Cordons	Iron Lark Company
Science	Isotope Choir	Green Lens Collective	Directive Archive	Signal Cartographers
Salvage	Scrim Salvage Compact	Rebuild Guild	Scrim Compact	Red Shipment Guild
Medical	Whisper Clinic	Hearth Clinic	Lace Clinic	Field Stitchers
Logistics	Basalt Exchange	Caravan Commons	Manifest Bureau	Convoy Registry
Ext. Corp	Helix Remnant Envoys	Helix Continuity Mission	Helix Compact Envoys	Helix Procurement Office
Ext. Smuggler	Seam Runners	Freeboot Relief	Seam Compact	Veil Route Brokers

When to pick which

Pick V1 if Dark Matter: Genesis should feel like cosmic survival horror with Io as the true boss and silence/frequency language as signature.

Pick V2 if the marketing pillar is colony hope, Building Control Panels, weather-as-schedule, and Phase 5 legacy.

Pick V3 if systemic drama should come from **people** (factions, Compact votes) more than the moon itself.

Pick V4 if the lead should be a **freelance terraform surveyor** with **two old-friend specialists**, Mars stranding backstory, **Kairos** ledger mystery, and Crimson Desert–like **contract-board spectacle** — terraform viability + missing expeditions drive the mission, not colony hope (V2) or parliamentary politics (V3).

Recommendation (default spine — user will still compare / change / pick)

Default spine: V2 Colony Horizon for GDD emotional fit and shipped Building Control / storm-shelter fantasy.

Steal from V1: Still Hunter / Silence / Resonance Shelf puzzle language for B3–B7 horror texture.

Steal from V3: Claim Barrier territory grammar + visitor cadence for faction boards.

Steal from V4: Freelancer player fantasy, Kairos prologue naming beat, contract board UX, old-friend starter trio, siege/escort setpieces — even if V2 remains narrative spine.

Do not ship all four AI truths in one build — lock one package spine and one Kairos truth variant.

File index

Doc	Markdown	PDF
V1	Assets/_Project/Documentation/Design/Narrative_Package_V1_Ash_And_Signal.md	.../Exports/Narrative_Package_V1_Ash_And_Signal.pdf
V2	Assets/_Project/Documentation/Design/Narrative_Package_V2_Colony_Horizon.md	.../Exports/Narrative_Package_V2_Colony_Horizon.pdf
V3	Assets/_Project/Documentation/Design/Narrative_Package_V3_Fracture_Compact.md	.../Exports/Narrative_Package_V3_Fracture_Compact.pdf
V4	Assets/_Project/Documentation/Design/Narrative_Package_V4_Crimson_Contract.md	.../Exports/Narrative_Package_V4_Crimson_Contract.pdf
Compare	Assets/_Project/Documentation/Design/Narrative_Package_Compare_And_Pick.md	.../Exports/Narrative_Package_Compare_And_Pick.pdf

Next implementation (out of scope for this doc pass)

1. Lock one AI truth + ending triad (+ Kairos prologue naming beat).
2. Author `QuestDefinition` assets from the chosen catalog (progress triggers for mainline; boards for sides).
3. Prototype Barrier Field + one faction reputation ladder.
4. Place POIs when biomes exist (prototype remains flat terrain).
5. Wire AC curve + named weapon reward tables into economy data.